

dangle fancy titles with greater power in company decisions, which leaves little room for the new birdie (you) to grow into the boss' shoes.

Reason #3: “The responsibility you’ll have is incomparable and you’ll be a well-equipped leader for later”

Responsibility in a startup is often a double-edged sword: you’ll have more clout but that doesn’t always translate into a better experience. While in a corporate the company assigns the mind-numbing, number crunching, *mechanical turk* work to an intern, at a startup the work must be spread around.

As the numbers increase, the quality of work regresses; plus, when hiring mistakes occur, the work-quality will be equal to the mean around you.

Reason #4: “Right now, we’re clearly undervalued. Another round of funding and we’ll be game”

This will be the oft-heard line when the founders pitch the company to a prospective employee. If the VC’s know what they’re doing and they mostly do, this means the founder massages the numbers to recruit new people. While not uncommon in startup pedagogy, quite often it spells trouble to new hires. Skim through PG (Paul Graham) or YC (YCombinator) posts and you’ll soon realize that team morale builds companies more than talent. Valuation gimmicks, leadership issues and greater fool theories have sunk more ships than product mismanagement.

Reason #5: Vesting, taxes and related mumbo-jumbo

- Join early into a fast-growing start-up and you will have the *golden handcuffs* - divest the shares only after 4 years at the company. If you’d like to leave early, then you must pay the associated taxes + value of options with your life savings and pray that the company gets acquired or goes public.
- In case you don’t pay upfront to hold the shares, the options technically expire in 3 months.
- Join too late, then the equity portion you have is worth peanuts because the valuation is diluted.
- If the company flounders and gets acquired for something below its last valuation - your shares are worth nothing.

With more legal jargon and many more combinations, one of the better solutions is if a company grows crazy fast and gets acquired by a giant for several multiples. But then, big giants often make acquisitions in IT, Telecom and SaaS ecosystems. Employees with Retail, lifestyle business options rarely see the liquidation-sun (rare ex. Dollar Shave Club).

If growth in the role and easier seniority were thought as a given, evidence suggests the opposite. The other option is to jump from one startup to another, but in the long run, changing industries is hugely detrimental to any hopes of a linear career ascension. While growth and an improved quality of work are not guaranteed in any measure, the next step